

The Himalayas



FROM THE FROZEN snow-covered peaks down to the hot forests on the lower slopes, the huge Himalayan Mountains provide a wide range of habitats for birds. On the bleakest rocky slopes, the bitterly cold weather causes the death of many animals, so bearded vultures, ravens, and other birds that eat dead animals have a steady food supply. In the warmer summer months, flower meadows further down the slopes are alive with buzzing insects. Accentors and redstarts eagerly snap these up, while the pigeons and partridges that also feed in these high meadows prefer to eat shoots and buds.

Many birds spend the summer feeding and nesting high up the mountains, but fly down to the sheltered forests in the foothills for the winter. These forests are rich in fruits and seeds and teem with mynahs, babblers, and parakeets. Many Himalayan forests have been cut down, and with fewer trees to soak up the rain and keep the soil firmly in place, water pours down the mountains causing serious floods.



Bar-headed goose
(*Anser indicus*)
Length: 2 ft 6 in (76 cm)

Flocks of geese fly in formation so that the wind flows past them more easily and doesn't hold them back.

Bar-headed goose

These geese breed in central Asia and migrate over the Himalayas—flying at record-breaking altitudes—to spend the winter in India. They rest by day near rivers and lakes. At night they graze in fields of crops, so farmers often shoot them. As they fly from one feeding ground to another, they make a wild, honking sound.

Bearded vulture
(*Gypaetus barbatus*)
Length: 4 ft (1 m 20 cm)
Wingspan: up to 9 ft 2 in (2 m 80 cm)



Stiff, black feathers hang down like a beard.

Long, thin tongue shaped like a garden trowel for scooping marrow from bones.

Bearded vulture

The acrobatic bearded vulture, or lammergeier, glides and soars over the high mountain slopes, searching for skeletons that have been picked clean by its cousin, the griffon vulture. The bearded vulture feeds on the marrow inside bones. The bird flies up to great heights and drops the bones on to rocks to smash them apart. It may drop one bone up to 50 times before breaking it. A bearded vulture will return to the same site year after year to crack open bones, and occasionally tortoise shells, in this way.

H I N D U
K U S H



Flutters its wings like a butterfly, so it is also known as the "butterfly bird."

The male has a black throat in summer.

Wallcreeper

The nimble wallcreeper climbs up sheer walls of rock, probing for insects with its curved, pointed bill. It often spreads out its wings to keep itself propped up while it searches. In summer, it moves high up the mountains, but in winter, it moves down to the shelter of the lower slopes.

Wallcreeper
(*Tichodroma muraria*)
Length: 7 in (17 cm)

BAR-HEADED GOOSE	HIMALAYAN MONAL
BEARDED VULTURE	HIMALAYAN BULBUL
WALLCREEPER	COMMON HILL MYNAH
HIMALAYAN SNOWCOCK	

I N D I A

Indus

Ganges

Brhadmaputra